

That adjustment is what creates harmony in a marriage, whereas heterogamy can increase the chances of discord and unhappiness. Does this mean you should automatically nix a partner who comes from a different background? Of course not. But you should be aware that you and your mate may face a greater number of challenges and difficulties than your homogamous friends. Keep in mind that marital counseling is expensive, and every hour you spend on your therapist's couch working through these issues adds up.

2. **Health.** Research has shown that couples who exercise together enjoy lower stress levels and greater happiness. Staying active will improve the intimacy in your relationship, giving you a much better shot of staying together. Linda and I met at a fitness center, and going to the gym is still a big part of our lifestyle today. But you don't have to pay pricey membership fees to stay in shape. Take a jog with your partner or even just a walk. Dust off the bicycles from your garage and cruise the neighborhood. There are dozens of ways to exercise without spending a penny. The couple that sweats together stays together.
3. **Social Tendencies.** An ironic consequence of our cyber-connected world is that couples today are more isolated from their communities than ever before. Instead of thriving among a rich network of friends and family, we tend to disengage. We come home from work and veg out to the TV or lose ourselves in our iPads. But studies have shown that couples do best when they engage in the larger community, be it through clubs, service organizations or religious groups. If your mate is a recluse, you may be headed for trouble. Look for someone who has roots—preferably deep ones. And find ways to engage in your community without it breaking the bank. Linda and I have always loved having people over